Chapter 11.

WHY BHARAT MATTERS

Grasping Our Value, Expressing Our Confidence

The successful landing of Chandrayaan-3 on the moon coincided with the BRICS Summit in South Africa. Predictably, that extraordinary achievement dominated the proceedings. Leaders of the Global South expressed pride that one of them was capable of such a feat. This is but one example of how much India is impacting the world today.

A few weeks later, the G20 Summit in New Delhi unanimously produced a substantive outcome. This diplomatic accomplishment was paralleled by the admission of the AU as a permanent member, that too at India's initiative. Here again, there was a larger resonance of these developments. In the years before, India's Vaccine Maitri effort provided health access for many small countries, otherwise forgotten in the pandemic. Three very different examples in very diverse domains have one message: that India matters to the world more and more.

A new generation of more globally aware Indians naturally debates our weight in world affairs. One way at approaching the issue is to consider why and how India matters to others. The answers are not always that simple, though they could start with the common-sense proposition that India has always mattered in some way. After all, such a large landmass with so many people and that rich a history and culture would naturally have made its impression. By its very existence, India occupies global mind-space and its growing vigour would only expand that appreciation. The questions now are really of the extent to which its revival is shaping the world order and what that portends for the future. This means choices, policies, leadership, delivery and, not least, an awareness of who we are and how we assert our collective persona.